

Your First 90 Days: the checklist

Managers were asked what separates the new hires who start strong from the ones who struggle. They named behaviors, not credentials. Mark yourself honestly on each one: doing it, or not yet. Save this file and come back to it.

	DOING IT	NOT YET
WHEN WORK LANDS ON YOU		
Ask clarifying questions before you start, not halfway through.	☐	☐
Write instructions down the first time, so nobody has to repeat them.	☐	☐
Come to meetings prepared: read the materials, know the client or project background.	☐	☐
Anticipate the next step. When you hand something in, ask what happens to it next, then start moving in that direction.	☐	☐
WHEN YOU HIT A WALL		
Bring a draft answer with your question. "Here is what I tried; am I close?" lands better than "How do I do this?"	☐	☐
Say you are stuck within a day. Struggling is normal; sitting on it quietly is what costs you trust.	☐	☐
Pick up the phone, or walk over, when a message thread stalls. If chat has gone back and forth without an answer, it is a conversation now.	☐	☐
HOW YOU BUILD A REPUTATION		
Close the loop yourself. When you say you will do something, it comes back done without a reminder from someone else.	☐	☐
Own mistakes before someone else finds them. Fast and plain: what happened, and what you are doing about it.	☐	☐
Show your checking. If AI or a template produced the answer, show where you verified it before you relied on it.	☐	☐
Ask for feedback before the formal review. "What is one thing I should do differently next week?" is enough. Managers consistently report giving far more feedback than new hires report receiving; asking is how you collect what they already think they are telling you.	☐	☐
Once you have your footing, volunteer for something outside your comfort zone.	☐	☐

Pick your two

Read the list again and pick the two items you would rather skip. Those two are yours. Run them deliberately for one week, then ask someone you work with what they noticed.

1.

2.

Two-sided version: around day 90, mark yourself, ask your manager or peer mentor to mark the same list, and talk about where the two line up and where they do not. Aligned or not yet; nobody is scoring anybody.